

All in the letter: In para athletics, track and jump events are denoted by the letter T, while field events take the letter F, followed by a numerical classification of disability class.

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myself having to deal with new space, new rules. I came in fully prepared for SL3 and its opponents, and I was so confident, but it was all taken away.

"I didn't play for two years. I was not prepared for that level of competition. It was in mid-2016 that I returned to an event in Ireland. I defeated the World No. 5 there and got my first international medal in my second international competition."

Complaints from compatriots

Former Paralympic Committee of India president Deepa Malik also has numerous such classification 'nightmares' that she now speaks about with a smile on her face.

A spinal tumour left her paralysed from the waist down, but Deepa found her calling in sports. Her journey began with swimming, but a lack of adequate facilities led her to switch to athletics.

In para athletics, track and jump events are denoted by the letter T, while field events take the letter F, followed by a numerical classification of disability class. Seated throws in javelin, shot put, discus, and club fall under the F51-58 bracket.

"I got classified in Taiwan in the F54 category in 2007. Two years later, I participated in the International Wheelchair and Amputee Sports Federation's World Games in 2009 in India.

"I was competing in the javelin throw, but I was told that I was going to be disqualified as I didn't belong to that particular class. That was pretty heartbreaking. I had to go for re-evaluation when I found that my results were not on the final sheet.

"A medical protest had been

raised about me not belonging to the F54 category. From there, I was surprised when they placed me in the F53 bracket, where the disability requirement was more severe."

In her new category, javelin — in which Deepa had won a silver and two bronze medals at the Asiad — was not an option.

"I randomly picked shot put. I had played it in school, so I knew the technique. I wanted to at least get a participation certificate, as a disqualification would be pretty demeaning. I finished with a bronze medal from there."

The 2010 Commonwealth Games came next, and it was the only year the F53 category was included in the roster.

"It felt like a silver lining. I felt very dejected about how it all turned out. I have a severe spinal cord injury, and sometimes this is what happens in disability categorisation. More unfortunately, a lot of these protests came from my own compatriots," she exclaimed.

"I had to undergo three more classification sessions. I would head to various competitions, and there would be a letter preceding my arrival.

"It's agonising to go through this mentally and emotionally, as this brings a lot of uncertainty. You're going all the way, with so much time and money spent, and sometimes you might not even be able to compete.

"Fortunately for me, after three such classification exercises, I was given a permanent confirmed class."

Deepa went on to win silver in the shot put F53 bracket at the Rio Games.

Need for sports literacy

Ekta Bhyan, a club thrower in the F51 bracket, registered a season's best effort of 20.12m to win gold in the women's F51 class at the World Para Athletics Championships in Kobe, Japan. However, by then she

knew her bracket wouldn't be included in the Paris Games — a normal passage in Olympics/Paralympics where sports and classes get rotated in and out of the roster.

An accident that damaged her spinal cord left Ekta with complete paralysis of her lower limbs and partial paralysis of her upper limbs. She was classified in the F51 category, which is for athletes whose movement is highly affected in the trunk, legs, and hands, with low to moderate impairment affecting arm movement. She generates all the momentum she needs from her shoulders and hands.

While the Paralympics is an evolving canopy, Ekta believes that plenty of resources are available to athletes, coaches, and governing bodies to figure out their para sports plans.

"The International Paralympic Committee (IPC) has a detailed guide on disabilities and their classification. For us, perhaps, the one issue is that this resource is in English. But lately, we've seen that the Sports Authority of India is recruiting para athletes as coaches, and they know the drill. There are domestic classifiers, but to be eligible for international events, you need to be assessed by the IPC's classifiers."

The only area of concern she identifies is the potential difference between how athletes are classified domestically and what happens in international classifiers.

Ekta was witness to what happened with Vinod Kumar. At the 2021 Tokyo Paralympics, the para discus thrower threw an Asian record mark of 19.91m to secure a bronze medal in the men's F52 class, adding to India's historic medal haul in a single edition.

However, within 24 hours, the former Border Security Force officer's medal was stripped away after multiple complaints from competitors casting doubts over his